Plan 4 · Sikkim: Gangtok, Silk Route & West Sikkim

Gangtok, Tsomgo Lake & Nathula, the Old Silk Route (Zuluk, Thambi, Nathang, Kupup), Aritar, Ravangla, Pelling, Rinchenpong, Darjeeling. 24 Dec 2026 – 3 Jan 2027 · Fly Hyderabad ↔ Bagdogra

At a glance

Route	HYD ✈ Bagdogra → Gangtok 3N → Zuluk 1N (Silk Route) → Aritar 1N → Ravangla 1N → Pelling 1N → Rinchenpong 1N (NYE) → Darjeeling 2N → Bagdogra ✈ HYD
Snow chances	High: Tsomgo, Nathula, Nathang, Kupup (often frozen lakes). Low–medium: Zuluk. None in Gangtok, Pelling, Darjeeling (but clear Kanchenjunga views are best in Dec–Jan)
Crowd level	Medium in Gangtok and Darjeeling (Christmas/NYE). Low on the Silk Route, Aritar, Ravangla, Rinchenpong
Difficulty	Easy, but high altitude: Nathula 4,310 m, Nathang ~4,100 m. Slow down and stay hydrated
Temperatures	Gangtok 4–13 °C · Pelling/Darjeeling 2–11 °C · Zuluk/Nathang −12 to 0 °C
Budget per person (6 people)	**≈ ₹33.8k shoestring** · **≈ ₹43.5k recommended** · lean version ≈ ₹29–31k (see box). **Flights make this the costliest plan.**

Honest budget note

Trains from Hyderabad to New Jalpaiguri take 35–42 h and their weekly days don't line up with 24 Dec (e.g. 15645 Charlapalli–Silchar via NJP runs Wed/Sat; 07572 special runs Fri). With only 10 days, **flying both ways is the practical choice**, and that alone is ₹13–17k.

Lean version to get close to ₹30k: book flights now (aim ≤ ₹6,500 each way), all 6 in one Innova/Bolero, shared seats to Tsomgo (skip Nathula), and do Gangtok 3N → Silk Route 2N → Pelling 3N → Siliguri, dropping Ravangla, Rinchenpong and Darjeeling (≈ ₹29–31k). Trains don't help: Hyderabad→NJP takes 35–42 h on weekly days that don't match 24 Dec.

Getting there and back

Flights Hyderabad ⇄ Bagdogra (main way in and out)

Route (non-stop)	Airlines	Flight time	Typical Dec–Jan one-way fare*	Useful for
Hyderabad ↔ Bagdogra	IndiGo (+ Air India Express)	~2 h 20 m	₹6,500–8,500 (peak ₹9–12k)	Plan 4

*Snapshot ranges from MakeMyTrip, Goibibo, Skyscanner, HappyFares, ixigo (Nov 2026), not live quotes. IndiGo: 7 kg cabin + 15 kg check-in on most fares. Fares climb weekly from here for 24 Dec and 2 Jan.

Leg	Option	Time	Approx cost
Bagdogra (IXB) → Gangtok	Reserved cab (small ₹3,000–3,500; SUV ₹3,500–4,500) or auto to Siliguri SNT / Panitanki then shared Sumo (₹400–550 per seat). Shared cabs don't wait at the airport	4–5 h (125 km)	₹500–750 pp (÷ 6)
Bagdogra luxury shared seat	Wizzride-type shared SUV seat from IXB/NJP	4–5 h	₹900–1,200 per seat
Darjeeling → Bagdogra	Reserved cab or shared jeep to Siliguri (₹250–350) + auto/taxi to IXB	3–3.5 h	₹450–670 pp (÷ 6)

Trains via New Jalpaiguri (only if you can leave or return on matching days)

Train	From Hyderabad	Runs	Duration	Notes
15645 Charlapalli–Silchar Exp (via NJP)	Charlapalli 16:25	Wed / Sat (sources differ)	~35.5 h to NJP	23 Dec Wed would be a day early
15673 Kacheguda–NJP Amrit Bharat	Kacheguda 19:40	Weekly (verify)	~41 h	Non-AC, cheapest (SL-type)
07572 Secunderabad–NJP special	Secunderabad 06:50	Fri (seasonal)	~38 h	Special train; may not run in Dec
12513/12514 Secunderabad ⇄ Guwahati/Silchar SF	Secunderabad	Weekly	~35 h to NJP	Return 12514 from Guwahati Thu, so NJP Thu → SC Sat 04:00

Alternative: fly Hyderabad → Kolkata (often ₹4–5.5k) + Vande Bharat Howrah → NJP (05:55 → 13:25, CC ≈ ₹1,500). Same cost as a direct Bagdogra flight but loses half a day. Only worth it if Bagdogra fares jump above ₹10k.

Getting around as 6

Option for 6 people	Seats / luggage	Typical hill rate (2025-26)	Per person per day (÷6)	When to choose
Innova Crysta with driver	6–7 + roof carrier	₹4,000–5,500/day (min ~250 km) or ₹16–18/km, + tolls, parking, ₹300–500 driver night	≈ ₹750–1,000	Default for 6 with soft bags
Tempo Traveller 12-seater	Lots of room	₹4,500–7,500/day or ₹18–22/km	≈ ₹850–1,250	Heavy luggage; not allowed on some narrow roads / union areas
2 × Dzire / Etios	4 + 4	₹2,800–3,500/day each	≈ ₹950–1,150	Only if no SUV is available
Local taxi unions (Manali, Pahalgam, Gangtok, Joshimath)	Innova / Tavera / Sumo	Fixed rate cards per circuit	Varies	Mandatory for some circuits (Solang–Sissu, Aru–Betaab, Tsomgo)
Government bus (HRTC / JKSRTC / UTC)	Seats	₹1.5–3 per km	Cheapest	Long point-to-point legs (Shimla→Manali, Delhi→hills)

Permits (Indian citizens)

Where	Permit	How	Cost
Gangtok, Ravangla, Pelling, Rinchenpong	None	—	—
Tsomgo Lake + Baba Mandir	Protected Area Permit	Registered agent / your hotel applies a day before (submit ID + photos by ~13:00 at MG Marg Tourist Info Centre). No solo permits; groups only	Included in the cab fare
Nathula Pass	Separate Nathula endorsement	Via registered agent, 1-day validity. Indians only. Usually closed Mon/Tue; snow can shut it	Govt fixed cab fare ₹6,500 (normal) / ₹7,000 (luxury) incl. permits
Silk Route: Zuluk, Nathang, Kupup	Restricted Area Permit	Through your Zuluk homestay/driver; issued at Rongli police station on the way	≈ ₹200–300 pp + vehicle pass
Lachung / Yumthang / Zero Point (optional swap)	PAP	Package from Gangtok. Reopening dates vary by report and heavy snow often closes it	₹4,000–6,000 pp 2D/1N package

Carry 4 passport photos and 2 Aadhaar copies per person. Permit counters close early, so give documents to the agent on arrival day.

Day-by-day itinerary

Day 1 · Thu 24 Dec · Hyderabad ✈ Bagdogra → Gangtok

• Morning IndiGo flight (~2 h 20 m). Taxi/shared cab to Gangtok (4–5 h along the Teesta, Rangpo checkpost, no permit for Gangtok).

• Hand over ID + photos to your hotel/agent tonight for the Tsomgo/Nathula permit on Day 3.

• Christmas Eve on **MG Marg** (lit up, no vehicles).

Stay: Airbnb Gangtok (3BR apartment) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹500–750 transfer + ₹600 food

Day 2 · Fri 25 Dec · Gangtok sightseeing (full-day cab ₹3,000–3,500)

• **Rumtek monastery** (Dharma Chakra Centre) → **Lingdum (Ranka) monastery** (offbeat, quiet) → Banjhakri falls → Namgyal Institute of Tibetology → Do Drul Chorten → Enchey monastery.

• **Tashi viewpoint** / **Ganesh Tok** / **Hanuman Tok** for Kanchenjunga at sunset. Gangtok ropeway (short ride).

• Evening: MG Marg Christmas, momos and thukpa at Lal Market side.

Stay: Airbnb Gangtok | **Day spend (per person):** ₹580 cab share + ₹300 entries + ₹700 food

Day 3 · Sat 26 Dec · Tsomgo Lake · Baba Mandir · Nathula (snow day)

• Leave 07:00 (permit vehicle). **Tsomgo (Changu) Lake**, 3,753 m, often frozen in December. Rent boots/coats at the lake stalls (₹100–200). Yak ride optional.

• **Baba Harbhajan Singh Mandir**, and **Nathula** (4,310 m; Indo-China border, Indians only) if permitted. Govt fixed cab fare ₹6,500–7,000 incl. permits. Tsomgo-only trips ≈ ₹4,500–5,500 per car or ₹1,000–1,500 per shared seat.

• Back by 15:00. Rest; altitude headaches are common.

Stay: Airbnb Gangtok | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,000–1,170 cab share + ₹200 rent + ₹700 food

Day 4 · Sun 27 Dec · Gangtok → Rongli (permit) → Zuluk · Old Silk Route

• Reserved vehicle for 2 days (≈ ₹10,000–14,000 incl. permits; your Zuluk homestay can arrange). Gangtok → Rongli (permit) → Lingtam → Padamchen → **Zuluk (2,850 m)**, about 4 h.

• Afternoon: **Lungthung** and the view over the 32 hairpin bends of the Zuluk road.

Stay: Zuluk homestay with all meals (₹1,000–1,500 pp) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,170 vehicle share + permit

Day 5 · Mon 28 Dec · Thambi sunrise · Nathang valley · Kupup → Aritar

• 04:45 drive to **Thambi viewpoint** for Kanchenjunga sunrise over the zig-zag road.

• **Nathang valley** (~4,100 m, often snowy, −10 °C), **Kupup / Elephant lake** (frozen), **Old Baba Mandir**, Tukla valley memorial.

• Descend to **Aritar**: **Lampokhari lake** (boot-shaped lake, boating), **Mankhim** viewpoint, Aritar gumpa.

Stay: Aritar homestay / lake-side lodge (₹1,500–2,500 per room) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,170 vehicle share + ₹700 food

Day 6 · Tue 29 Dec · Aritar → Temi → Ravangla

• Drive via Rorathang–Singtam (≈ ₹3,500 per car, or shared jeeps with 1–2 changes).

• **Temi Tea Garden** (Sikkim's only tea estate), **Buddha Park (Tathagata Tsal)** with its 130 ft Buddha, **Ralang monastery** (offbeat).

Stay: Ravangla homestay (₹1,200–2,000 per room) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹670 cab share + ₹100 entry + ₹700 food

Day 7 · Wed 30 Dec · Ravangla → Pelling (West Sikkim)

• Shared jeep via Legship (₹200–300) or cab (₹2,800–3,500).

• **Pelling Skywalk & Chenrezig statue**, **Pemayangtse monastery**, **Rabdentse ruins** (17th-c. capital), sunset over Kanchenjunga.

Stay: Pelling homestay / guesthouse (Airbnb is thin here) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹580 transfer share + ₹200 entries + ₹700 food

Day 8 · Thu 31 Dec · Khecheopalri lake · Kanchenjunga falls → Rinchenpong (quiet NYE)

• Half-day cab: **Khecheopalri (wishing) lake**, **Kanchenjunga falls**, Rimbi falls.

• Short drive to **Rinchenpong** (offbeat): **Resum monastery** walk, Poison Lake, Kaluk. Kanchenjunga sunset across the valley. NYE bonfire at a homestay.

Stay: Rinchenpong homestay (₹1,200–2,000 per room) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,000 cab share + ₹800 food/NYE

Day 9 · Fri 1 Jan · Rinchenpong → Jorethang → Darjeeling

• ≈ 4 h via Jorethang (shared jeeps via Jorethang ₹400–500 total, or cab ₹4,000–5,000).

• Evening: Chowrasta, Mall Road, Glenary's / Keventer's, Darjeeling tea shops.

Stay: Airbnb Darjeeling | **Day spend (per person):** ₹450–830 transfer + ₹700 food

Day 10 · Sat 2 Jan · Tiger Hill sunrise · Toy train · Darjeeling

• 04:00 **Tiger Hill** sunrise over Kanchenjunga (shared jeep or cab ₹1,500–2,000) → **Ghoom monastery** → **Batasia Loop**.

• **DHR toy train joyride** Darjeeling–Ghum (UNESCO; ₹800–1,500, book on IRCTC; festive specials run till 3 Jan 2027).

• Japanese Peace Pagoda, Happy Valley tea estate, HMI + Padmaja Naidu zoo (closed Thursdays).

Stay: Airbnb Darjeeling | **Day spend (per person):** ₹420 cab share + ₹1,000 toy train + ₹700 food

Day 11 · Sun 3 Jan · Darjeeling → Bagdogra ✈ Hyderabad

• Leave by 07:00 (3–3.5 h; fog in the plains can slow you down). Take a midday/afternoon flight, not an early-morning one.

Day spend (per person): ₹450–670 transfer

Where you sleep: Airbnb picks for 6 (best-rated and budget)

Nights	Area	Best-rated pick	Budget pick	Est. Dec price, 6 people / night	≈ per person / night
3 (24–26 Dec)	Gangtok	**Zimchung 101**: 3 BR, 6 guests, 4.88★ (216), Guest favourite · **Luxury Loft** 3 BR, 9 guests, 4.9★ (165)	**Bob's Bnb** 3BR apartment, 6 guests, 4.83★ (54) · **Orchid Stays MG Marg** 3BR, 4.71★ (24)	₹5,000–7,500	₹850–1,250
5 (27–31 Dec)	Zuluk, Aritar, Ravangla, Pelling, Rin chenpong	Mostly **not on Airbnb**: family homestays booked by phone / your driver, or on Booking.com / MakeMyTrip	Zuluk homestays ≈ ₹1,000–1,500 pp with all meals; others 3 rooms × ₹1,500–2,500	₹4,500–7,500	₹750–1,250
2 (1–2 Jan)	Darjeeling	**Shiv Sai Homestay** (entire 3BR unit, 4.71★, 59 reviews) · **Homestay with Mountain View** (3 BR, 4.56★, 52)	**Drokpa's Rest** 3BR (4.44★, 9) · 'Super spacious for 8 guests' apartment	₹5,500–9,000	₹900–1,500

Listing names, ratings and review counts come from Airbnb search results in Nov 2026. Airbnb blocks automated price checks, so the 'Dec price for 6' column is an **estimate** for an entire 3-bedroom place over the holiday week. Check the live total for your dates.

How to pick the best-rated vs the cheapest on Airbnb

Filters: Guests = 6 · Type of place = **Entire home** · Bedrooms ≥ 3 (or 2 + sofa-beds) · tick **Guest favourite** · toggle **'Display total before taxes'** so the price includes cleaning and service fees.

Best-rated vs cheapest: sort by price after setting the filters, then pick the cheapest listing with ≥ 4.7★ and ≥ 20 reviews. A 5.0★ with 3 reviews is not more reliable than a 4.8★ with 150.

Winter questions to message the host before booking: room heaters (some charge ₹300–500/night per heater), geyser/hot water, power backup, whether a car reaches the door (Old Manali, Vashisht, Jibhi and McLeodganj often have steep stairs), and snow-time access.

NYE rules: many hosts set a 2–3 night minimum for 30 Dec–1 Jan. Book those nights first with flexible or moderate cancellation.

Where Airbnb is thin (Zuluk, Aritar, Rinchenpong, Sari/Chopta, Sangla/Kalpa, Bandipur, Spiti), book homestays by phone or on Booking.com / MakeMyTrip. Usually 3 rooms × ₹1,500–3,000 with meals.

Offbeat vs main in this plan

Place	Type	Why
Gangtok MG Marg, Rumtek, Tashi viewpoint	Main	Capital, monasteries, Kanchenjunga views
Lingdum monastery	Offbeat	Large, quiet monastery 20 km from Gangtok
Tsomgo Lake, Baba Mandir, Nathula	Main	Frozen lake, border pass, snow
Zuluk, Thambi, Nathang, Kupup	Offbeat	Old Silk Route: zig-zag road, high snow valley, frozen lakes
Aritar (Lampokhari, Mankhim)	Offbeat	Lake village in East Sikkim
Temi tea garden, Ravangla Buddha Park, Ralang	Semi-offbeat	Tea slopes and monasteries
Pelling (Skywalk, Pemayangtse, Rabdentse)	Main	West Sikkim's Kanchenjunga balcony
Khecheopalri, Kanchenjunga falls	Main	Sacred lake, waterfalls
Rinchenpong, Resum, Kaluk	Offbeat	Quiet ridge villages with big mountain views
Darjeeling: Tiger Hill, toy train, Batasia	Main	Classic hill station

Bike / scooty rentals

Where	Rates	Rules / advice
Siliguri (most choice)	Scooty ₹500–800 · 150–350 cc ₹900–1,800	WB-registered rentals can ride to Gangtok. For Tsomgo/Nathula/Silk Route, permits are needed and outside-state vehicles may be refused (Sikkim is also considering limits on two-wheelers in permit areas). Get written confirmation from the rental shop
Gangtok	Scooty ≈ ₹699 per 24 h · bikes ₹1,200–2,000	Fuel/tolls/parking extra. Fine for Gangtok–Rumtek–Ranka on dry days
Pelling / Darjeeling	Limited; ₹700–1,500	Steep roads and early dark (17:00). Taxis are simpler

Advice: don't ride to Tsomgo, Nathula or Zuluk in December. Frozen roads above 3,000 m and permit rules make reserved local vehicles with experienced drivers the right call.

Winter gear: what to buy, what to rent, and where

Gear budget: if you own nothing warm, expect ₹4,000–6,500 one-time purchase (thermals, fleece, gloves, cap, socks, sunglasses) + ₹800–1,500 rentals on the trip. Plan budgets include only the rentals. Six people can share: buy 2 pairs of microspikes and 1 first-aid kit for the group instead of 6.

Item	Need	Buy (Decathlon Hyderabad / local)	Rent (where & rate)	Advice
Thermal inner set (top + bottom) ×2	Must	₹800–1,200 per set (local ₹400–600)	Not rented (hygiene)	Buy. Merino/poly, not cotton

Item	Need	Buy (Decathlon Hyderabad / local)	Rent (where & rate)	Advice
Fleece / sweater (mid layer)	Must	₹600–1,200	—	Buy
Padded / down jacket (−5 to −10 °C)	Must	₹2,500–5,000	Indiahikes rentals ₹55–80/day (ships to you); trek operators ₹100/day; Manali / Gulmarg shops ₹150–300/day	Rent if you won't reuse it: 10 days ≈ ₹600–1,000
One-piece snow suit	Snow points	—	Solang/Palchan, Kufri, Gulmarg, Tsomgo ₹250–500/day (often with gumboots)	Rent on the spot
Gumboots / snow boots	Snow points	—	₹100–200/day (bundled with suit at Solang ₹400–500)	Rent on the spot
Waterproof trekking shoes	Treks	₹2,000–3,500 (Decathlon MH100/MH500)	Trek operators ₹100–150/day	Buy if you'll trek again
Waterproof gloves + woollen inners	Must	₹300–900 + ₹150	—	Buy
Woollen cap / balaclava / neck gaiter	Must	₹200–400 each	—	Buy
Woollen socks (4 pairs)	Must	₹400–600	—	Buy
UV400 sunglasses	Snow	₹300–800	—	Prevents snow-blindness
Microspikes + gaiters	Treks / icy walks	₹1,200–1,800	Chopta/Sari/Sankri/Dharamkot ₹150–250/day; gaiters ₹100/day	Rent

Rental points on this route

Point	What you can rent	Rate
Tsomgo Lake stalls (on the way)	Long coats, gumboots, gloves	₹100–200 per item
Zuluk / Nathang	Few rentals; homestays may lend gumboots	Carry your own warm layers
Lachung (if you swap in North Sikkim)	Snow boots	≈ ₹100 per pair
Gangtok Lal Market / Darjeeling Mall (buy)	Cheap jackets, gloves, caps	₹300–1,500

Budget per person (6 people sharing)

Item (per person, 6 sharing)	Shoestring	Recommended	Notes
Flight Hyderabad → Bagdogra	₹6,500	₹8,500	Book now; 24 Dec fares climb
Flight Bagdogra → Hyderabad	₹6,500	₹8,500	
Bagdogra → Gangtok	₹500	₹750	Shared Sumo from Siliguri vs reserved SUV ÷ 6
Gangtok sightseeing cab	₹580	₹580	≈ ₹3,500 ÷ 6
Tsomgo (+ Nathula)	₹1,000	₹1,170	Shared seats Tsomgo only vs govt-fixed ₹7,000 Nathula cab ÷ 6
Silk Route vehicle 2 days incl. permits	₹2,330	₹2,330	≈ ₹14k ÷ 6
Aritar → Ravangla → Pelling (+ Pelling local)	₹1,200	₹1,750	Shared jeeps vs cabs
Pelling → Rinchenpong → Darjeeling	₹650	₹1,100	
Darjeeling local + transfer to Bagdogra	₹800	₹1,100	
Stays, 10 nights (Airbnb Gangtok/Darjeeling + homestays)	₹7,500	₹9,500	3BR apartments / 3 rooms ÷ 6
Food	₹4,500	₹5,000	Zuluk homestay includes meals
Toy train joyride	₹0	₹1,000	Optional
Entries, permits, misc	₹500	₹700	
Gear rentals	₹400	₹500	
Buffer	₹800	₹1,000	
TOTAL per person	**₹33,760**	**₹43,480**	**Over ₹25–30k because of flights. The lean version in the box above gets close to ₹30k.**

Bookings to do now

- Flights HYD⇄IXB (24 Dec out, 3 Jan midday back). Check IndiGo directly; fares rise every week from here.
- Gangtok hotel for 24–27 Dec through someone who can also arrange the Tsomgo/Nathula permit vehicle.
- Zuluk homestay (they arrange the Silk Route vehicle + Rongli permit), Darjeeling for 1–2 Jan (NYE-week demand).
- DHR joyride on IRCTC ~2–3 weeks ahead.

Plan B

- Nathula closed (snow/days): Tsomgo + Baba Mandir only (cheaper), or Hanuman Tok + Ganesh Tok half-day.
- Silk Route snowed in above Zuluk: stay low (Aritar + Rolep/Reshi), or swap to **Okhrey / Hee-Bermiok** in West Sikkim, or Lachung if it's open.
- Want North Sikkim (Lachung–Yumthang–Zero Point)? Swap Days 4–5 for a 2D/1N Gangtok package. Status changed several times in 2025–26 and Zero Point is often closed by snow, so confirm the week before.

Carry list

- Original photo ID (Aadhaar/DL) + 2 photocopies + **4 passport photos** each (Sikkim/Bhutan permits, J&K checks). **Nepal: passport or voter ID** (Aadhaar is generally not accepted).
- Power bank (cold halves battery life), offline maps, ₹5–8k cash each (ATMs fail in snow areas).

- Group med kit: paracetamol, ORS, cold/cough tablets, band-aids, Vaseline, motion-sickness tablets (hill roads). Diamox only on a doctor's advice.
- Thermos for hot water, quick-dry towel, plastic bags for wet gear, a 3-pin multi-plug for the Airbnb (one socket per room is common).
- Prepaid SIMs from outside J&K don't work in Kashmir. Carry at least 2 postpaid connections in the group (Plan 3).

Safety & buffers

- Roads and snow change by the hour. Check state police traffic updates and ask your host each evening. Emergency: **112**. HP disaster helpline: **1077**.
- No two-wheelers on fresh snow or black ice. Taxis with chains are safer after snowfall.
- Book 30 Dec–1 Jan stays first (NYE rates 2–3×). Prefer flexible cancellation.
- Start the last long leg (hills → Delhi/railhead) by 1 Jan. NYE traffic and snow delay buses 3–8 h.
- High altitude (Nathula, Nathang): no alcohol the night before, climb slowly, carry dry fruits and water; turn back if headache + nausea worsen.
- Sikkim bans plastic bottles at many tourist spots. Carry a refillable bottle.

Sources checked

Reddit and direct page fetches (Airbnb, IRCTC, erail, ConfirmTkt) were blocked from this environment, so everything here comes from web-search results: Airbnb listing snippets, rail timetable aggregators, Team-BHP, Tripoto, travel blogs and local news. Live seat availability and live prices could not be checked; use the checklists above to verify.

— Nathula/Tsomgo fixed taxi fares (₹6,500/₹7,000 incl. permits): India Today NE, Outlook Traveller, Club Mahindra (2024 order)
— Permit process and Silk Route permit at Rongli: muddietrails Sikkim permits, trekkingsikkim, darjeeling-tourism.com
— North Sikkim reopening reports (conflicting 2025–26 dates): WanderOn, UNI India, sikkimdarjeelingtourism, muddietrails
— Bagdogra/NJP → Gangtok shared & reserved rates: darjeeling-tourism.com, banbanjara, darjeelingtravels.in (2026)
— Bike rules: bikewalebhaiya.com Sikkim guides, ridesiliguri, newkerala (Sikkim mulls two-wheeler limits, Aug 2026)
— Trains to NJP (15645, 15673, 07572, 12513): erail/gettraininfo/ixigo/railyatri listings via search (running days conflict)
— DHR toy train joyride fares & festive specials till 3 Jan 2027: Outlook Traveller, Curly Tales, ETV Bharat, RailMitra
— HYD–IXB flights: IndiGo route page, HappyFares, Skyscanner, Kayak (Nov 2026)
— Winter offbeat ideas (Zuluk, Kecheopalri, Lachung boots): TravelTriangle, Thrillophilia, Tripoto traveller notes